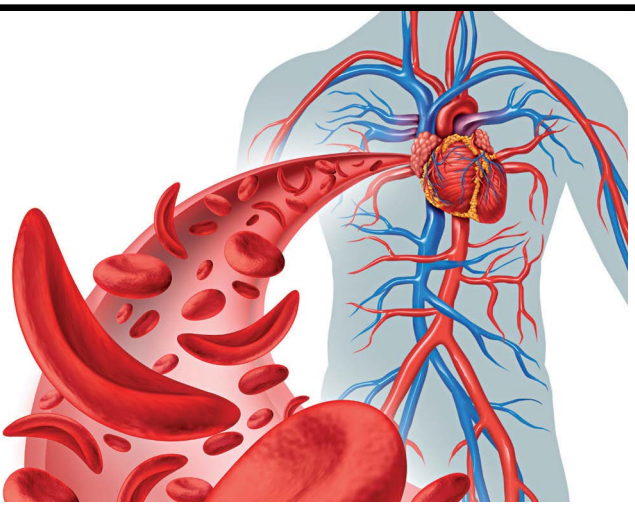


SHUTTERSTOCK

on the patient's age. The drugs used include hydroxyurea, L-glutamine, Voxelotor and Crilanlizumab. SCD mainly affects the tribal population in India. The Union ministry of tribal affairs pegs its prevalence in the community at 1 in every 86 births. In MP, the state with the highest tribal population, a haemoglobinopathy mission has been functional since 2021 in all 89 tribal blocks. Around 1.6 million have been screened so far, of which 18,866 were found to have SCT while 6,500 had SCD.

"The best solution will be for people with SCD to not marry and have children. At a practical level, however, it is challenging to get people to even get a blood test for screening," says Raipur-based Dr A.R. Dalla, president of 'Project Sickle'. "Unfortunately, sickle cell anaemia seems to be more prevalent among the dark-skinned and poor, which is perhaps why it does not get as much attention from policymakers and even the media," he says. ■



GETTY IMAGES

Industry-specific seminars, B2B conferences and sector-specific trade exhibitions used to be the highlight. But the showstopper was the announcement of the number of Memorandums of Understanding (MoU) signed and the amount of investment these MoUs would bring in and the employment they would generate. Over the years, ratcheting up these numbers was the focal point for the administration.

When Modi moved to Delhi as the prime minister, the event lost its significance and glamour. Three VGGS have been held since 2014—in 2015, 2017 and 2019. Modi has presided over the opening ceremony of each event, but since the original purpose with which the event had been conceptualised was not central to its organisation any more, the summit was losing its punch. Hence, the need to reinvent. "Though the BJP continues in its political pole position, we are not oblivious of the fact that there is anti-incumbency. We need to mobilise the MSMEs—essentially the middle class in the 'rurban' areas—ahead of the polls," says a BJP veteran.

Expanding the scope of the event by taking its miniature versions to lesser-developed areas of Gujarat is a step that's being welcomed by industry. This month, the

LOCAL SMALL PLAYERS HAVE NEVER FULLY JOINED THE SUMMIT: THAT WILL CHANGE

GCCI drew up a list of talukas that required special attention for industrial development. Industrial activity is concentrated in and around urban centres. This is putting pressure on the resources of each of these regions, driving up the costs of setting up shop. Non-agricultural jobs are also limited to these select 3-4 regions, prompting migration and a plethora of social issues associated with it. "We have requested the government to reclassify talukas under the Gujarat Industrial Policy. Investments in backward talukas can be incentivised and infrastructure can be developed and the destinations marketed to attract investment here," Patwari adds.

Industrial clusters have naturally formed in the state, but concentrated near urban centres in the absence of a focused thrust on equitable distribution. For instance, Surat in south Gujarat is the hub of diamond polishing and textiles, but the tribal areas in the region have not had any spillover benefit from their proximity. Similarly, Bharuch and Ankleshwar in the central region are hubs of chemical manufacturing. Ahmedabad and its surrounding areas too benefit from industrial activity. The northern region is turning into a nerve centre of auto parts manufacturing. Rajkot is into heavy engineering while Jamnagar is a centre of brass parts manufacturing and trading, and Morbi of ceramics industry. But the tribal districts bordering Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan as also the districts adjoining Maharashtra have lesser industrial presence.

As Gujarat prepares its local landscapes for its next global summit, one hopes the government reads the writing on the wall—the need for a more equitable approach to industrial development. ■